

A close-up photograph of a coral hermit crab. The crab's legs, which are purple with red stripes, are visible as it peeks out from a hole in a yellow, textured coral reef. The background is a soft-focus view of the reef.

Holed up

Peering out of a hole in the reef, a coral hermit crab waves its feathery antennae to collect food. Unlike crabs that live in the open, this finger-sized crustacean has a long, soft abdomen. The hermit crab protects its body by living in an abandoned hole made by a tube worm in the coral. Every few months, the crab grows too big for its current home and has to search for new lodgings. This is a dangerous time, so the crab often explores at night, when there is less risk of being seen and attacked by predators.